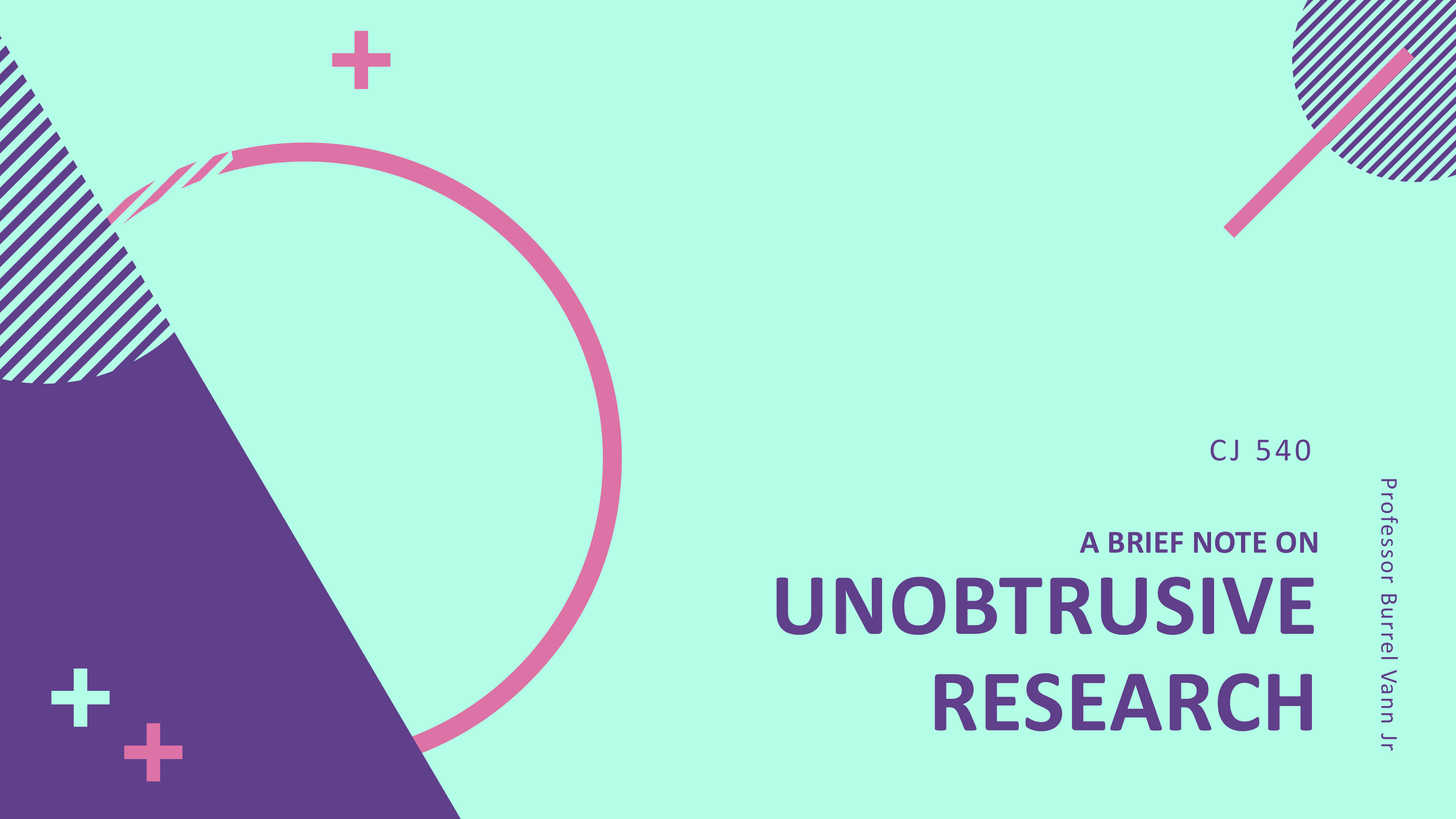




CJ 540

A BRIEF NOTE ON

UNOBTRUSIVE RESEARCH

Professor Burrell Vann Jr

Methods of studying social life without affecting it

Can be:

- Qualitative
- Quantitative



Unobtrusive Research

Qualitative

- Content Analysis/Text Analysis
- *Case Study (Historical)*
- *Comparative Historical*

Quantitative

- Secondary Data Analysis

TYPES OF UNOBTRUSIVE RESEARCH



CONTENT ANALYSIS



The study of recorded human communications (text).

- Can be books, newspapers, websites, paintings, laws, blogs, texts, etc.

“Who says what, to whom, why, how, and with what effect?”

Key Questions



What are your operational definitions?

What will you observe?

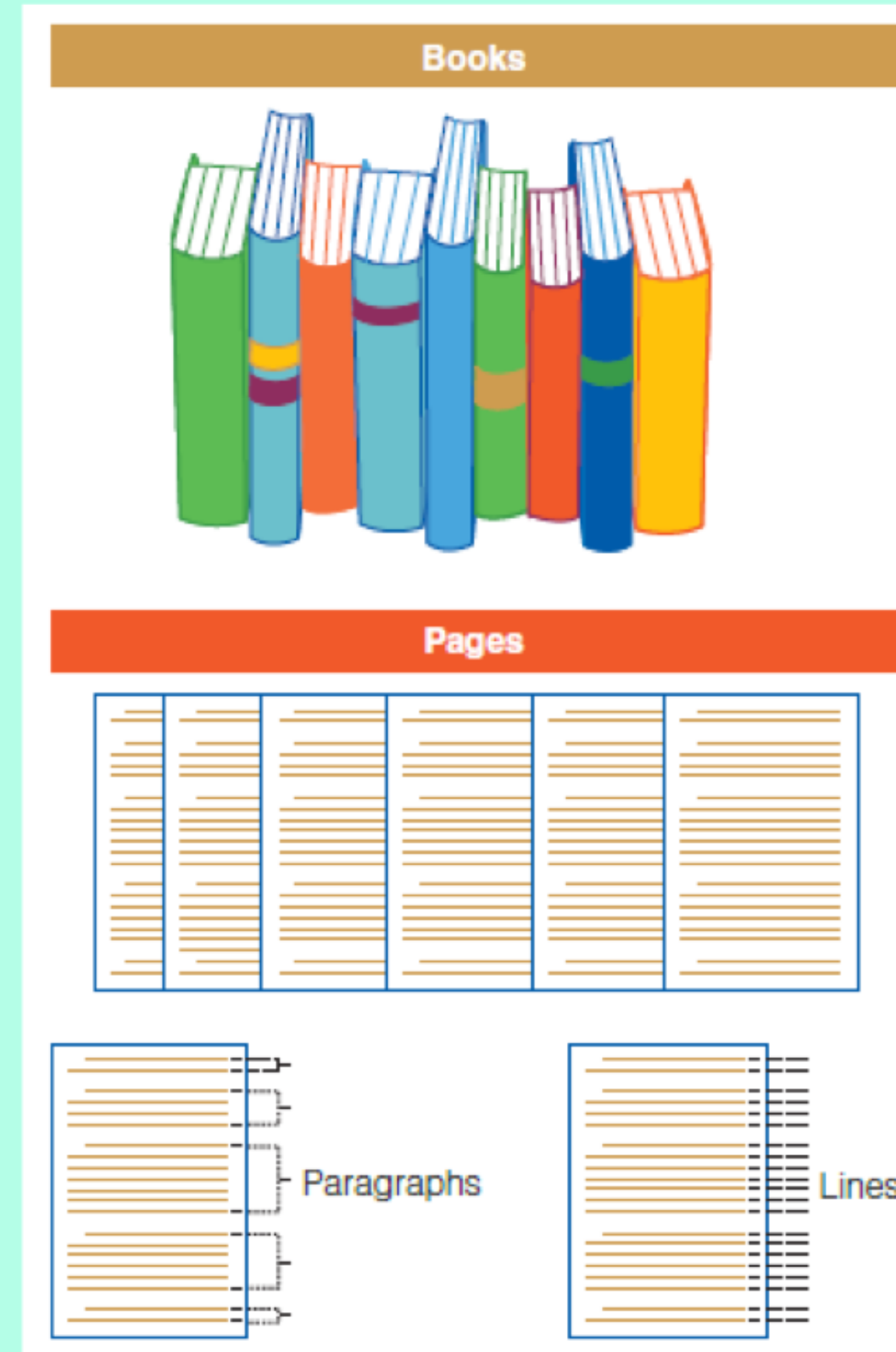
How will you analyze the data?

How will you measure your key variables?

What are your units of analysis?

CONTENT ANALYSIS

+ Units of Analysis



CONTENT ANALYSIS



Sampling

Any conventional sampling technique may be used for content analysis.

CONTENT ANALYSIS



Coding

Transforming raw data into a standardized form for analysis.

Newspaper ID	Number of editorials evaluated	SUBJECTIVE EVALUATION			
		1. Very liberal	2. Moderately liberal	3. Middle-of-the-road	4. Moderately conservative
001	37	2	0	8	0
002	26	5	10	0	6
003	44	4	2	1	2
004	22	3	1	2	3
005	30	1	0	6	0

CONTENT ANALYSIS

MANIFEST CODING

The concrete terms contained in a communication.

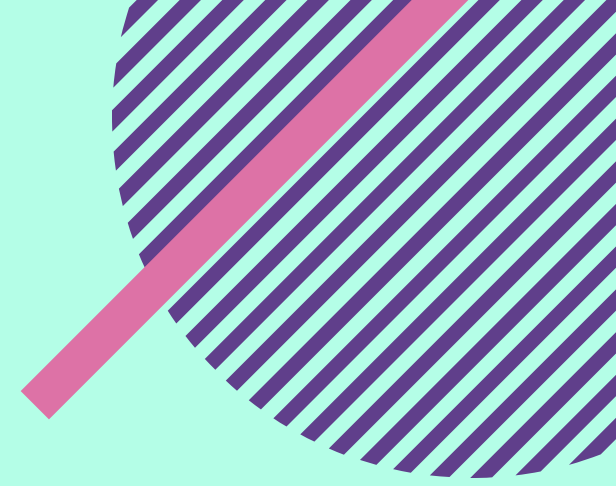
- involves the counting of specific elements, such as the word love, to determine whether and to what degree the passage should be judged “romantic.”

LATENT CODING

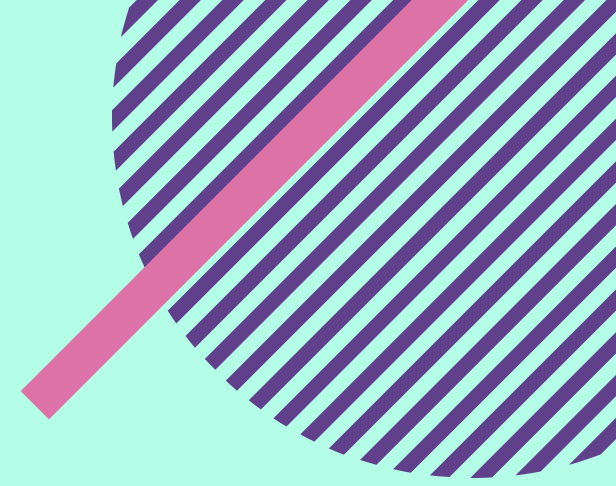
The underlying meaning of communication.

- view entire unit of analysis (a paragraph in this case) and make a subjective assessment regarding whether and to what degree it is “romantic.”

Coding Types



CONTENT ANALYSIS



STRENGTHS

- Time and money
- Correction of errors
- Study of processes occurring over time
- Research has virtually no effect on subjects
- Reliability

WEAKNESSES

- Limited to recorded communications
- Validity

Coding Types

SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS



Using quantitative data collected by other researchers

- survey responses
- administrative data
- Census data: city, county, state-level (e.g. crime, voting, education, non-profits, organizations, events,

SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

Units of Analysis

Individual

Groups

City, County, State

SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

Sources of Existing Statistics:

Statistical Abstract of the United States

Census

Pew Research Center

Public Policy Institute of California's Data Depot

The World Bank Data Catalog

The Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research